

INSIGHT · PROCESSING

A number made only of refined metal cannot be moved by ore.

What America's 45 per cent copper import reliance actually measures.





THE NUMERATOR

807 of 1,807. Rounded to 45 per cent.

Imported as refined metal	810
Exported as refined metal	less 60
Drawn from refined stocks	plus 57
Net imports	807

Every term is refined metal. Mine output never enters the figure.

Thousand tonnes, 2024 estimates.
USGS Mineral Commodity Summaries, January 2025, p64.

THE PART THAT CUTS THE OTHER WAY

Take out the stock draw and 2024 reads like 2022.

45% → 41.5%

As published, against the same year without the stock adjustment.

Some 57 thousand tonnes of the 807 came out of warehouses, not across a border. The survey puts 2022 and 2023 at 41 per cent.

One year decomposed, denominator held constant.

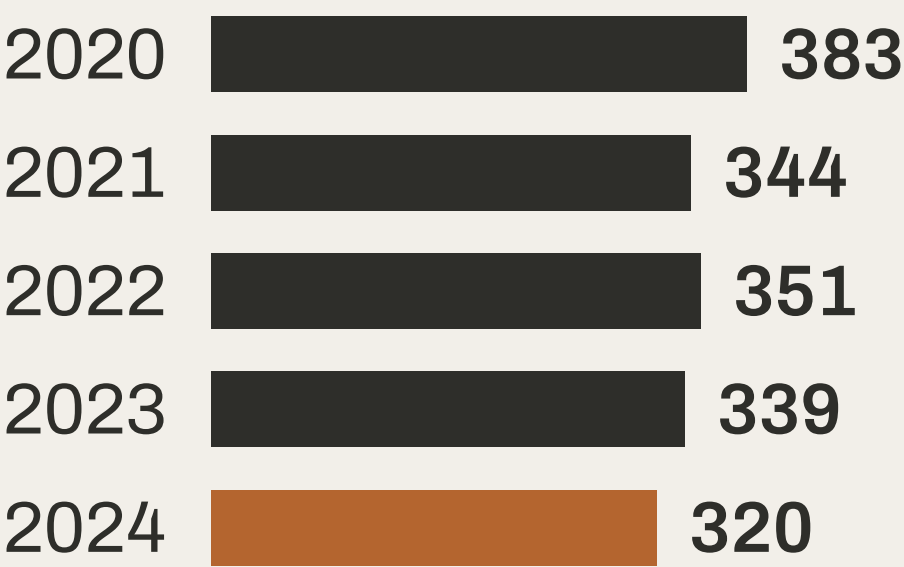
USGS Mineral Commodity Summaries, January 2025, p64.



FIVE YEARS

Copper leaves as concentrate every year.

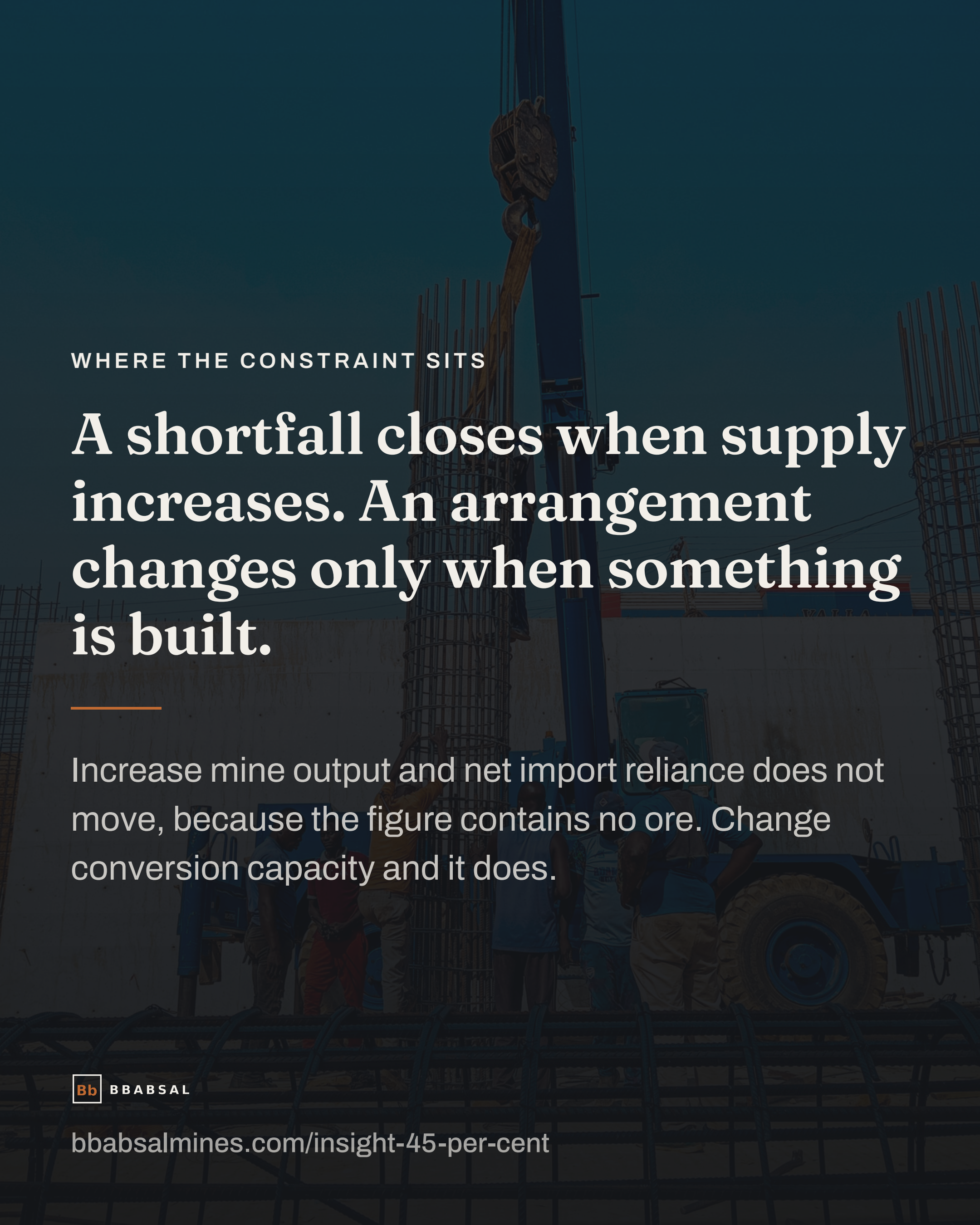
US exports of copper ore and concentrate, thousand tonnes



Refined imports rose from 676 to 810 over the same years. One year is an anomaly. Five is a configuration.



Zero baseline, bars proportional to value.
USGS MCS, January 2025, p64.



WHERE THE CONSTRAINT SITS

A shortfall closes when supply increases. An arrangement changes only when something is built.

Increase mine output and net import reliance does not move, because the figure contains no ore. Change conversion capacity and it does.